

you tens of thousands of dollars; if you were to jump in confidently, you might get to someone's limit before they do.

The professional guide to bidding

Buyers' advocate and valuer Greville Pabst has bought thousands of homes for clients. He has also purchased properties on several past seasons of *The Block*, and has acted as the renovation show's official valuer. Away from the spotlight he does this week in, week out, with icy composure.

Here are Pabst's pro secrets to gun bidding:

Maintain gameface

As per the advice above – 'Don't exchange worried looks' – the moment your facial expression crumbles and your body language deteriorates, your competition knows they have you beaten. Your demise will be swift, so wear a poker face. 'Stay calm and take the emotion out of it. You can see the young couples who are telegraphing their emotions, nudging each other, turning up their noses and then putting in another bid. If you are a professional buyer you love to see that, because you know you will just kill them. If you are nervous, don't turn up to the auction. Have someone to bid for you.'

Be ultra-observant

At 'open for inspections' – of which you should attend many for the same property – you will repeatedly see the same people, who you will then see again at the auction. Tattoo these faces on your brain. Pabst says the giveaways of other bidders can be slight. For example, a family who bring their children to the inspections but attend the auction without the little ones in tow have eliminated distraction – a sign they are serious and will bid.

Shhh!

Professional buyers do not talk about price in front of anyone at the inspections. Don't give away your limit: 'It's a mistake before you even get to the auction.'